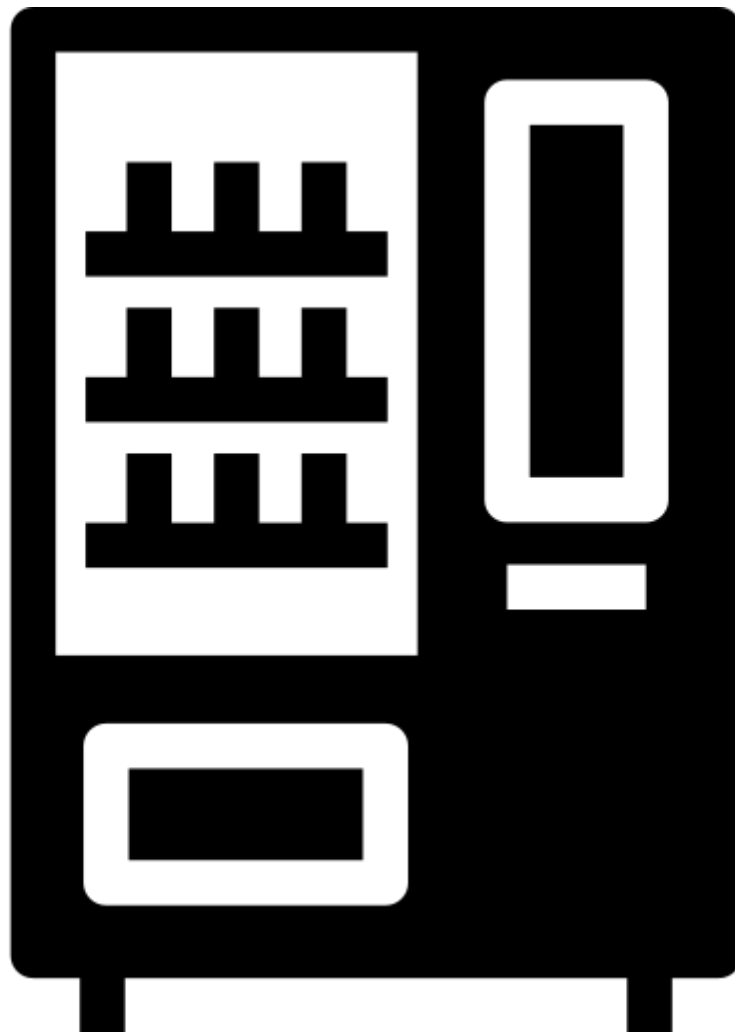


SnackTime

How much is your time worth?



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Introduction

People often say that “time is money”. But how often do you think about that when you go about your day? Do you choose to take a cheaper alternative to go to work, even if it would be slower than just paying some extra money for a car? SnackTime forces participants to confront themselves with their own valuation of time. Won’t you come get a bite to eat?

The Scientific Insight

The insight we chose is that the value of someone’s time varies wildly from person to person. This stemmed from a discussion about how little money would still be worth picking up from the ground if you saw it on the street. Even within our small group we had answers that varied from 5 cents to 50, and this led us to believe that this insight might inspire many different reactions from people. While we were hesitant about linking the concepts of time and money together — mostly due to how well-known and clichéd the phrase “time is money” is — we found that we were a lot more enthusiastic about the potential directions we could take the idea compared to other insights we focused on before. Furthermore, people’s perception of money in relation to time is an often-researched topic in academic fields such as psychology (Devoe, 2019; Leclerc et al. 1995; Lehmann & Reimann, 2012), meaning that our chosen insight has proven scientific interest vested in it.

We believe the insight is interesting because it highlights economic inequality and one’s personal valuation of time. A CEO of a large company would most likely value their time as being a lot more expensive than someone who is working a minimum-wage job, which would in turn affect their decision-making, purchasing habits, and in general the way they go about their day. A more concrete example of this could be someone choosing to hire a personal chef to save time that would otherwise be spent on cooking their own meals, even though a personal chef is a lot more expensive money-wise. But even barring extreme cases like this, we can see how people differ in their daily habits based on their personal valuation of their time. Someone might rather choose to brew their own coffee at home, being a lot cheaper but slower than grabbing a cup on their way to work from Starbucks.

Translation into Experience

We chose to have people literally purchase items with their time. If someone just asks you how much time you would be willing to spend for a certain item, it can be hard to know if the answer you give would be consistent with how much you would actually spend. For this reason, we thought it was imperative to make the hypothetical question

of what your time is worth a real and physical experience, forcing participants to truly be confronted by their own evaluation of their time. We feel that this engagement adds a more personalized layer to the experience, hopefully spurring participants to think more about their own valuation of time in a way that they have not thought about it before.

The Statement

The statement we derived from our insight is as follows: “How much is your time worth?” We are aware that this is formulated as a question, not as a statement. However, we felt that this phrasing would much better communicate the concept behind our project. It is also a more personal way to deliver the concept, as the question is very specifically directed to the participant. In combination with the physical nature of our experience, we believe that phrasing our statement as a question will invite the participants to reflect on it more, as a question naturally expects an answer. At the same time, because there is no “right answer”, it strengthens the idea that one’s valuation of time is a personal matter.

The Work

The installation is, in essence, a vending machine. Like a regular vending machine, participants can view items, select items, and, after paying, receive the item they selected. The twist, however, is that participants can only pay with their time. After selecting an item, the vending machine will only vend its contents after the participant has held down two buttons located on opposite sides of the machines for a certain amount of time. After the purchase is completed, a thermal printer will print a receipt for the participant which lists what they bought and the time they spent waiting for it. The receipt also has a QR code which redirects participants to a website which further describes our project.

The amount of time that a participant needs to wait to purchase something is based on the price of the item in a chain supermarket and the average hourly wage of a Dutch citizen (€27,10). For example, a small 40g bag of Lays Chips costs €0,75 at Jumbo, a large supermarket chain in the Netherlands. We then take that price and divide it by the previously mentioned average wage divided by 60, making it into the average wage per minute (which comes out to roughly €0,45). 0,75 divided by 0,45 comes out to 100 seconds or 1 minute and 40 seconds, which would then be the amount of time that a participant would need to wait in order to purchase it. However, we realize that this time might be too short or too long for most participants, which might cause problems on the day of the presentation. For that reason, we added in a function that allows us to

change the pricing for all the items if we see that we are selling out too quickly or not selling out at all.

The Experience

We feel that purchasing items with your time is a very direct way of experiencing our statement. This was backed up during a preliminary presentation of a prototype of the work when participants mentioned that they instantly understood what the work was about. The reason we chose to use the concept of a vending machine instead of a more traditional storefront was because buying something at a vending machine is a solitary experience. There is no person manning a register who you need to interact with to make the purchase. The only actors involved are the participant and the vending machine.

The physical act of holding two buttons simultaneously for the required duration not only limits mobility but also prevents multitasking. This makes the waiting period feel more deliberate and conscious. It removes everyday distractions and creates space for reflection, emphasizing that time is being spent in a real and irreversible way. In addition, it also makes the work stand out, as seeing someone “hug” a vending machine is quite a peculiar sight. To add to this feeling, “No Refunds” is printed on the receipt. Speaking of the receipt, by giving participants something that they can keep even after the experience is finished, we allow more opportunity for reflecting on the experience after the fact.

Finally, the QR code which is printed on the receipt will show participants more detailed information about what our project is about, allowing them to read through it at a later time.

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